

Why play sports in high school?

Playing high school sports such as basketball, football, tennis, or others gives students the opportunity to connect with a larger variety of people on a different level. I mean, making a friend while being tackled down onto the field is much different than saying “Hi” to a new classmate, isn’t it? Sports can give students a more personal level of understanding and mutual companionship, which can even extend into adulthood friendships or even personal careers.

However, sports aren’t just about making friends. It’s about showing colleges *who you are*.

A long-time commitment to sports, combined with strong academics, essays, and more, shows colleges your character as well as how versatile and well-rounded you are as an individual.

A strong involvement in sports throughout your high school career can display strong traits such as leadership, time management, discipline, communication, passion, and many other strong qualities that colleges value. These traits are reflected on the individual, giving colleges a better understanding of who you are and how capable you are as both a student and an athlete, and could potentially have a significant impact on your college application.

- College admissions

You should ask your teachers/coaches for recommendations later in your high school career (usually around 11th grade/junior year). Colleges especially value recommendations from someone who knows you for the long-term!

So, make sure you talk to your coaches and show strong character throughout your time in sports.

What sports are in high school

Although the sports actually available at your specific school may vary, common sports in high school include football, baseball, basketball, soccer, tennis, golf, and others. There may also be clubs for sports that aren't "officially" offered as a school course, such as Badminton Club, Pickleball Club, Bowling Club, or others.

Tip: If there's a sport you're interested in but isn't offered at school as either a course or as a club, you could become the founder of a club for that sport! This can expose other students to activities they may have never heard about, or allow students who were already interested but didn't have a place in school to finally be able to play with others.

This also shows colleges' strong initiative and leadership potential as part of your college application, significantly boosting your chances of being accepted to your dream school!

PE requirement

In KatyISD, students are required to fulfill 1.0 credit of "PE" at any time throughout their four years in high school. But don't be alarmed! You don't have to take, for example, football AND a PE course. In the KatyISD district, sports fulfill this requirement. So, if you've signed up for a sports course like Football or baseball, for example, and it's on your physical schedule, completing one year of the sport completes this PE requirement. Of course, you can continue with the sport for the rest of high school even after finishing the requirement.

Don't skip this! Make sure to note that playing a sport as part of a club that's not a course offering/ in your schedule does NOT count towards your PE requirement.

How does it count towards GPA?

Although you might want to play sports in high school, there is something you should consider: the effect on your GPA.

In KatyISD, for example, having a sports course in your schedule is a 4.0, meaning it counts the same as an ACA course (see Nidhish's page for more specific GPA breakdowns).

Don't skip this either! Playing a sport that's not a course offering/ in your schedule doesn't count towards the GPA because, well, it's not going to be in your transcript (which is like an album of every class you took, as well as your grades, that's used to calculate your GPA).

So, if your goal is to obtain the highest GPA possible, saving your sports requirement until 12th grade, also known as senior year, is likely something you're considering. However, waiting until 12th grade also has its own downsides. Waiting until senior year means missing out on a lot of the friends, activities, events, and memories that people cherish and rejoice in when it comes time to leave high school.

A more physical downside, however, is more blunt; an incoming senior **MUST** make the varsity team, or they're cut. This might not be true for all sports in high school, but for sports like tennis, you either make it or you don't.

Tryout process

As mentioned previously, going to sports as an incoming 12th grader/senior often means you either make it or you're cut.

The tryouts for sports are often held sometime in the summer. When it specifically is would be depending on the sport, and even when the coaches set the tryout date, so make sure you join your sports' mode of communication, ex, SportsYou, to stay updated.

Your coaches may also hold practices for anyone who is going to be trying out in the weeks leading up to your actual tryout. If you can, attend them! This gives you a chance to talk to your coaches and peers who may have already been on the team, and make new friends. This gives you the opportunity to find out what the school year with your involvement in sports is like, and overall gives you a feel for what your new homecourt/homefield feels and looks like.

Important: A Physical (from RankOne and to be submitted to RankONE) is required to try out for your chosen sport. Physicals do expire, so you should renew them anytime after May 1st. However, keep in mind when your tryout date is. It can be difficult to get a Physical form filled out by a doctor on short notice, so keep that timeframe in mind. If possible, getting the Physical form filled at the start of the summer is most likely optimal, as most students may be waiting later into the middle/end of the summer to get their Physicals checked.

A Health is also required, which can be found from the same place you'll find the Physical Form on the RankOne website.

The Physical and Health Form pictures should be taken separately, as the RankOne upload submission will most likely ask for their files to be uploaded separately.

Tips for tryouts: Don't feel pressured during these practices or during your actual tryouts! I know you've probably heard something like this before, but it's crucial to understand. Just because someone is older or more experienced or looks cooler, or any other reason, doesn't mean you need to shrink up mentally. Play your best! Play the game you love and the game you've practiced, and win! Even if you lose, playing the way you love the game can show the coach how passionate and how strong your mentality and mindset are in a live match.

Good luck and have fun at tryouts!

Practice schedule/time commitment

After playing your very best and making the team, your Coach may inform or post you about your practice schedule and your game days. Practices can vary from early in the morning at 5:30 or 6 am to after school when the sun is raining down.

However, it's important, especially as a 9th grader, to show up to practice as much as possible to show your commitment and dedication to improving your game.

At the end of the day, Coach doesn't care if you're the best player in the world but you don't show up to practice and don't care for the team. In high school, sports are a team effort, not an individual one. Even if you're playing a 1v1, your whole team is there to cheer you and your peers on, no matter what. Your team is your community.

Tournaments

Although it's usually more common in the second semester, you might miss an entire day of school to be out with your sports team.

Always remember to stay on top of your school work. You are primarily a student, after all.

Make sure to alert your teachers in advance if you know you're going to miss a day of school for a game/tournament with your team so you and your teacher can set up a time to do make-up work or a quiz/test.

GPA exemption

If you have signed up to play your sport for two or more years in a row, you should be eligible for a GPA exemption.

The GPA exemption tile for KatyISD is called “GPA Exempt”, and begins IN 10th grade. You should apply for this as soon as possible after the year starts. If it’s your second year in the course in a row, you should be able to click on it to exempt the class from your transcript/GPA.

Each student only gets 3.0 credits of total GPA exemptions

0.5 credits = 1 semester, so to GPA exempt the whole year of the course it will take 1.0 credits

What does it mean?

It means that the sports course you’re in can be absolved or released from the 4.0 GPA that comes with taking the class.

In other words, this simply means that it doesn’t count towards your GPA.

Strategically, GPA exempting the class can boost your GPA if you’re above a 4.0 GPA, since it takes away the equivalent of an ACA course (or getting a B in a KAP or AP class), boosting your GPA closer to a 5.0.

Costs

The specific costs depend on the sport, but all sports’ fees are payable through the Pay ‘N Go tile for KatyISD.